lose some of the inspiration from the previous Friday night. Having beaten the tournament favorites, all of a sudden we were expected to take care of anybody else in our way without breaking a sweat. As it turned out, sweat was the one thing we did do in Osaka come Wednesday afternoon.

We went into the Nigeria match wanting to win it. Finishing top of the group meant we probably wouldn't have to face Brazil until the final. And we wouldn't play them in the kind of conditions we had to prepare for in Osaka. The extreme heat had been talked about in the build-up to the tournament: games that kicked off in the middle of the afternoon would be difficult, especially against non-European sides who were used to playing in temperatures of 95 degrees plus. None of us realized how tough it would be, though, until we went out on the day to warm up. We jogged up and down the field once and players were looking around at each other. *How are we supposed to play in this?*

The heat stood up in front of you like a wall. Not a breath of wind. Sweat rolling off you just standing still. When it's that hot, you feel claustrophobic. The air's heavy: it wraps itself around you, stealing your breath. We knew Nigeria could play, but I didn't have any doubts about us beating them. I was just worried we might not be able to beat the conditions.

It was a game we never felt we'd lose. The longer it went on, the more it felt like we'd never win it either. Ninety minutes of hard labor. We got a 0–0 and we advanced to play Denmark in the next round. There wasn't any more to be said about it: the players sat in the dressing room, gulping water, throats almost too dry to drink the stuff. The match itself is like a blur in my memory now. What's sharp is how we felt for hours afterwards: absolutely wrung out, drained, physically and mentally. We all dipped over the next couple of days. We didn't doubt ourselves but we were aware that, back home, some people were wondering if the Argentina game had been a fluke. We'd finished second in Group F behind Sweden. Were England good enough now to go forward?

Talking to Victoria and Brooklyn helped keep me going. I missed my family. I had a videophone set up in my hotel room and I could talk to Victoria face to face: when your wife's seven months pregnant you want to know about every last kick and twinge. We'd plenty to say without even mentioning the games in Japan. Time on the phone to home was a break from soccer and a break from the tension. I even got to see and talk to Brooklyn on the videophone: he would sit there chatting to me or showing off his new bike as he rode it round and round the bedroom.